

url4 topology — node, host, discovery, addressing, transport

Sharp definitions before the Engine grows further

STATUS	proposed — owner review; one decision left open in §5
WORK ITEM	OME-1110
DATE	2026-09-04
OWNER	Sergey Bershadsky (execution and telemetry architecture)
GRAMMAR OWNER	Kevin McDonough (URL4 spec, Parts A/B)
SPEC POINTERS	URL4.ai Specification v0.5 DRAFT, Parts A (§1) and B (§2-§8); pre-v0.5 monolith v0.2 for §9-§40

Read §0 first. Everything else is the reasoning behind one line of that table.
One decision is left open for the owner, in §5.

0. The eight answers

This document fixes the words we use for the pieces of url4. It is short on purpose. Each section states a definition, says where the spec agrees or is silent, and stops.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER
1	What is a node?	A stateless function behind a path. It takes <code>(context)!intent</code> and returns a result. Every node can evaluate a full url4 expression.
2	What is a host?	The origin <code>(scheme://authority)</code> that mounts one or more nodes at paths and answers discovery. <code>/</code> is its default node.
3	Swarm? Composition?	Not protocol words. The expression is the composition. The hosts it touches are its request tree. “Swarm” is only a deployment word for one operator’s hosts.
4	<code>.well-known</code> or OPTIONS?	Both are documented in §5 with their trade-offs. The owner picks there.
5	<code>/name</code> vs <code>url4://name</code> ?	<code>/name</code> is a node mounted on the host that is evaluating. <code>url4://name</code> is host <code>name</code> ’s default node <code>/</code> . Spec Part B §5.4 already says this.
6	Where does an ensemble run?	Wherever an evaluator runs: the SDK on a laptop, or a host. A local host may mount remote nodes under local names (proxy mounts).
7	Can I test a host first?	One fetch of the host’s capabilities document, or one OPTIONS per node (§5). A separate “plan” concept is deferred (§9).
8	Streaming fallback?	Ask for <code>stream</code> in one GET; accept whatever comes back. <code>stream</code> → <code>sync</code> , <code>sync</code> → <code>async</code> , and <code>any</code> → <code>sync</code> (§6). WebSocket is never a node transport.

What changes against today

- The Engine becomes a url4 **host**. Today no url4 node is reachable over HTTP; the SDK’s node-to-node code is unused.
- Node streaming is **SSE on the same GET**, as the spec says. WebSocket stays for the product client only.
- Two spec words move: the spec’s Node becomes our Host; the spec’s Endpoint becomes our Node. Appendix A asks Kevin for the rename.

1. Terms

Eight words. Each has one meaning.

OUR WORD	MEANING	SPEC WORD TODAY	IN THE SDK	IN THE ENGINE
Node	A stateless function at a path. Accepts <code>GET <path>?q=<expr></code> , evaluates it, returns a result plus envelope.	Endpoint (Part A §1.4)	an entry in <code>Url4Node</code> ’s endpoint registry	a route such as <code>/anthropic/<model></code>
Host	An origin that mounts nodes at paths, serves <code>/</code> as the default node, and answers discovery.	Node (Part A §1.4)	<code>Url4Node</code> (the class name lags; Appendix B)	the App, after this change
Mount	The binding of a path to a node implementation: <code>local</code> (in-process), <code>command</code> (subprocess), or <code>proxy</code> (forwards to a declared remote node).	not defined	<code>endpoint()</code> , <code>[commands]</code> , —	in-process handlers only
Evaluator	Whatever runs an expression: resolves sources, fans out, reduces, runs the intent. Every node contains one.	“the node executes” (Part A §1)	<code>url4.dag.run</code>	<code>Url4Executor</code> in the Runner

OUR WORD	MEANING	SPEC WORD TODAY	IN THE SDK	IN THE ENGINE
Intent processor	The thing inside a node that turns resolved context plus intent into a result: a model call, a script, a command.	Intent processor (Part A §1.4)	endpoint handler	one httpx call to aigateway
Requestor	Whoever sends an expression.	Requestor (Part A §1.4)	Client	product client
Request tree	The hosts and nodes one expression touches. Strict tree, never a graph (v0.2 §16.1).	“request tree”, “call tree” (v0.2 §22)	the compiled DAG, per node	one run
Capabilities document	JSON a host publishes to say which nodes, mounts, features and delivery modes it offers.	named in Part A §1.4; schema unwritten (Part G)	none	none

Words we do not use in the protocol: ensembler, orchestrator, swarm, composition, plan, fusion. “Fusion” stays product copy.

2. Addressing

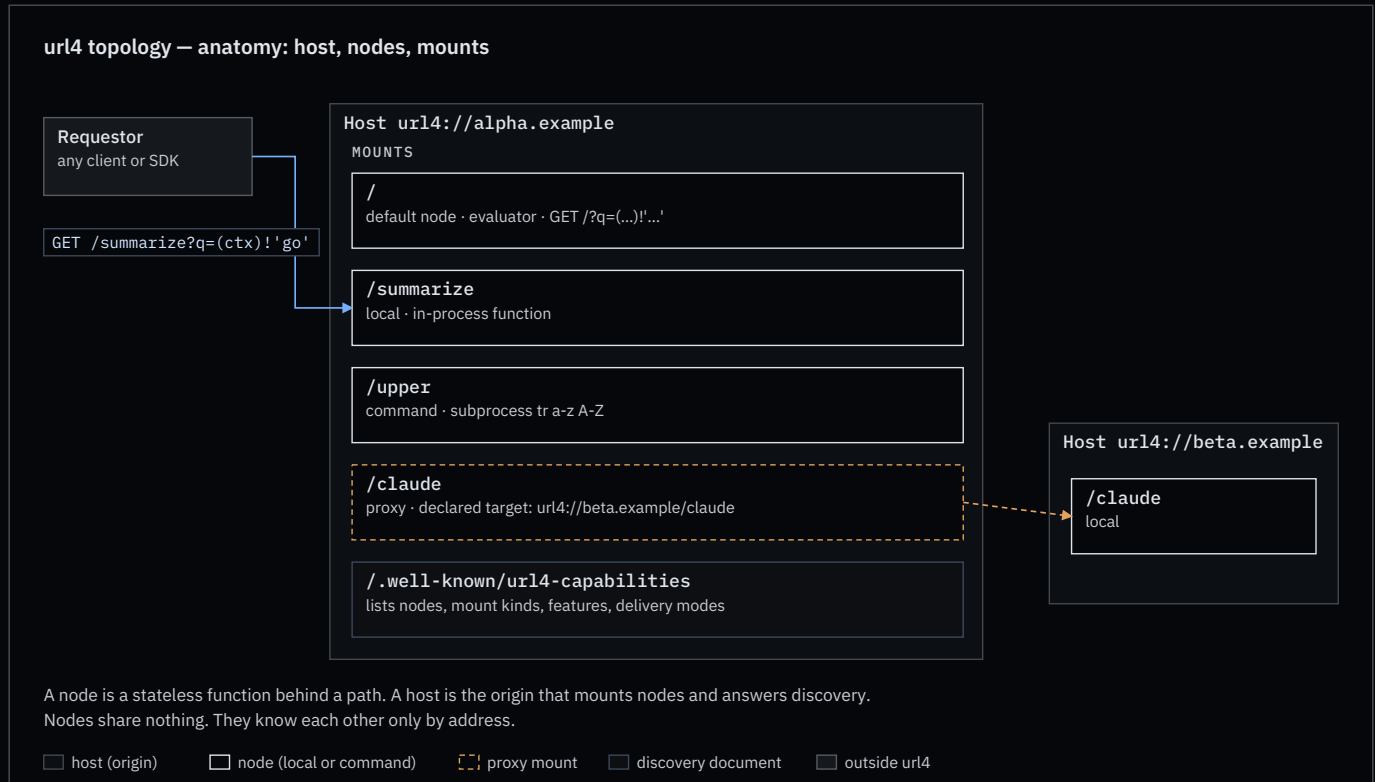
Three address forms. The spec fixes their meaning in Part B §3.1.1 and §5.4; we add one rule about the root.



Scheme inheritance. A bare relative data URI inherits the scheme of the request that carried it (Part B §5.4.1). Under `url4://` it is a url4 read; under `https://` it is a plain read.

3. Node contract

A node is a function. That is the whole idea.



A node:

- **MUST** answer `GET <path>?q=<expression>` and evaluate the expression. Every node evaluates url4; a node may walk a DAG before it reaches its own intent processor. There is one grade of node, not two.
- **MUST** be stateless per invocation. It keeps nothing between calls. Its own data is reached through `@` (Part B §5.6) and lives behind it, not in it. Multi-turn work uses an explicit session key (`;coord=`, Part B §4.2), never process memory.
- **MUST** return the envelope (v0.2 §13) and state the delivery mode it actually used (v0.2 §11.4).
- **MUST NOT** resolve `@` inside a sub-expression addressed to another host (Part B §5.6.3.1).
- **SHOULD** stream with SSE when asked (§6) and **MUST** answer sync when it cannot.
- **MAY** be mounted on any host, or be its own origin. A Lambda-style function with its own URL is a host with one node.
- Speaks GET. Other verbs are 405, except the ones this document adds: `DELETE` on a run handle (§6) and, if adopted, `OPTIONS` (§5).

Nodes share nothing. A node knows another node only by address, and only because the expression named it.

4. Host contract

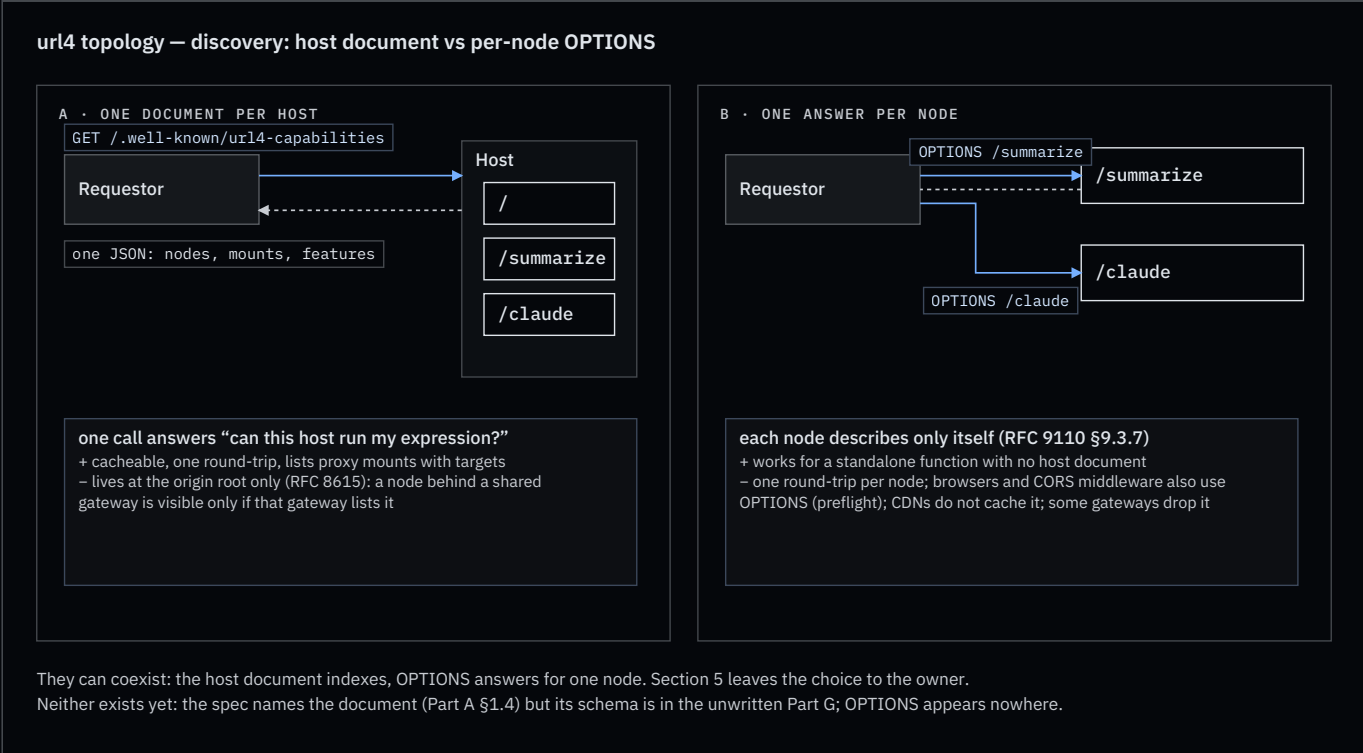
A host is an origin. It routes; it does not evaluate.

- Mounts one or more nodes at paths. `/` is the default node.
- Mount kinds: `local` (a function in the process), `command` (a subprocess; doctrine N4), `proxy` (forwards the sub-request verbatim to a declared target on another host).

- Declares proxy mounts with their targets in its capabilities document. Attribution and consumer disclosure (v0.2 §16.2.2) need the real target, so proxies are never hidden.
- Serves discovery (§5) and the version alias `/v1` (§2).
- A local SDK process that mounts remote nodes under local names is a host. That is how “run the ensemble on my laptop, but call `/claude` as if it were mine” works.

5. Discovery — the open decision

Two ways for a requestor to learn what a host can do. Neither exists yet: the spec names the capabilities document (Part A §1.4) but its schema is in the unwritten Part G; OPTIONS appears nowhere in the spec.



Both share one hazard: the Engine’s JWT header is called `URL4-Capability`. The document is “capabilities”. Appendix B proposes renaming the header.

Draft capabilities document (host level; a node’s OPTIONS answer is the one entry for that node):

```
{
  "url4": "0.5",
  "host": "url4://alpha.example",
  "default_node": "/",
  "nodes": {
    "/": { "mount": "local", "delivery": ["sync", "stream"],
          "features": ["nesting", "iteration", "broadcast", "self_ref"] },
    "/summarize": { "mount": "local", "delivery": ["sync"] },
    "/upper": { "mount": "command", "delivery": ["sync"] },
    "/claude": { "mount": "proxy", "target": "url4://beta.example/claude" }
  },
  "holdings": { "collections": ["default", "science"], "self_ref_support": true }
}
```

Owner decision (open). Pick one:

☐

A only — host document is a MUST; nothing per node.

☐

B only — OPTIONS per node is a MUST; no host document.

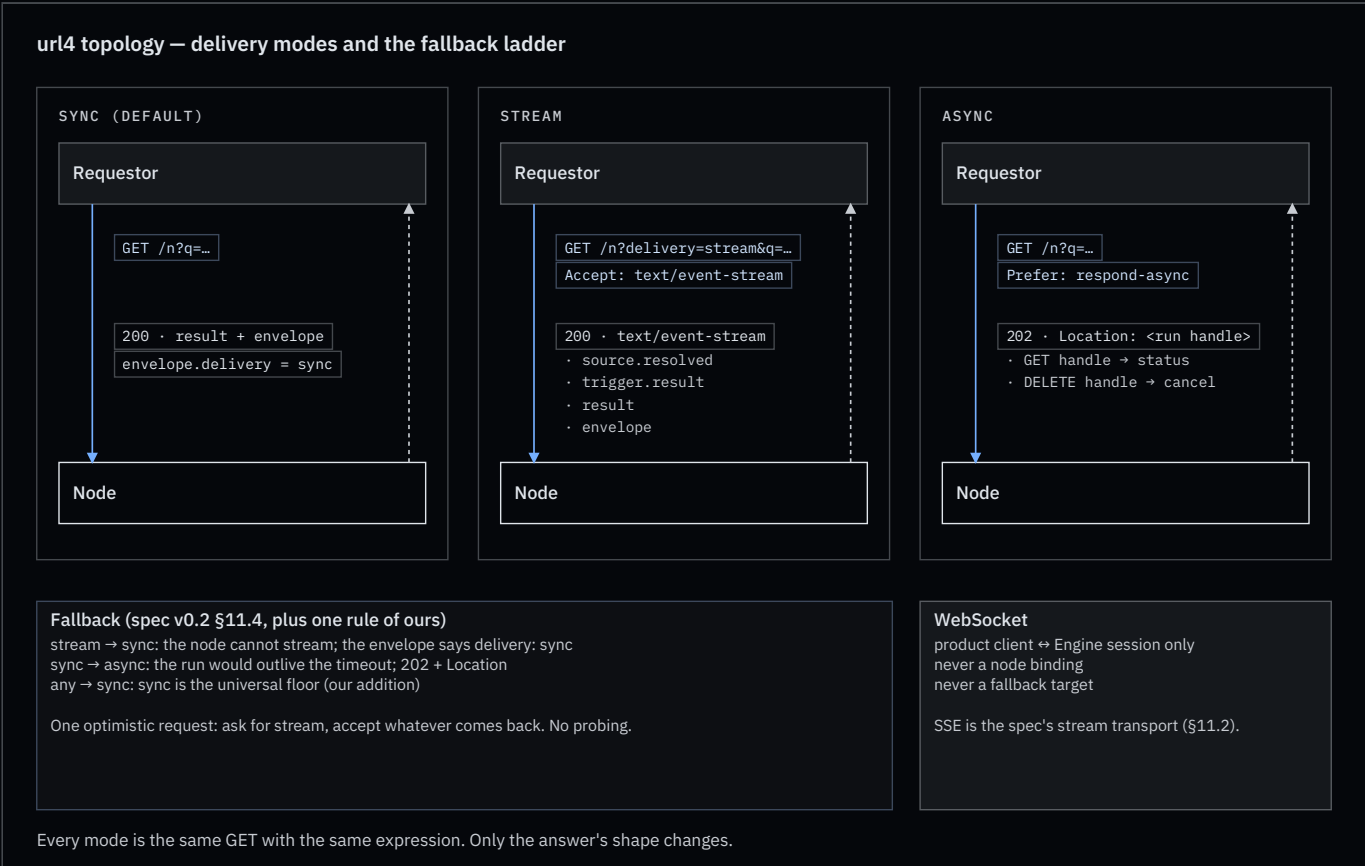
☐

A MUST + B SHOULD — the document indexes the host; a node may also answer OPTIONS with its own entry.

Recommendation: A MUST + B SHOULD. A alone fails the standalone-function-behind-a-gateway case; B alone fails the single-call test in answer 7.

6. Delivery and transport

The spec defines three delivery modes and a fallback rule (v0.2 §11). We adopt them and add one rule.



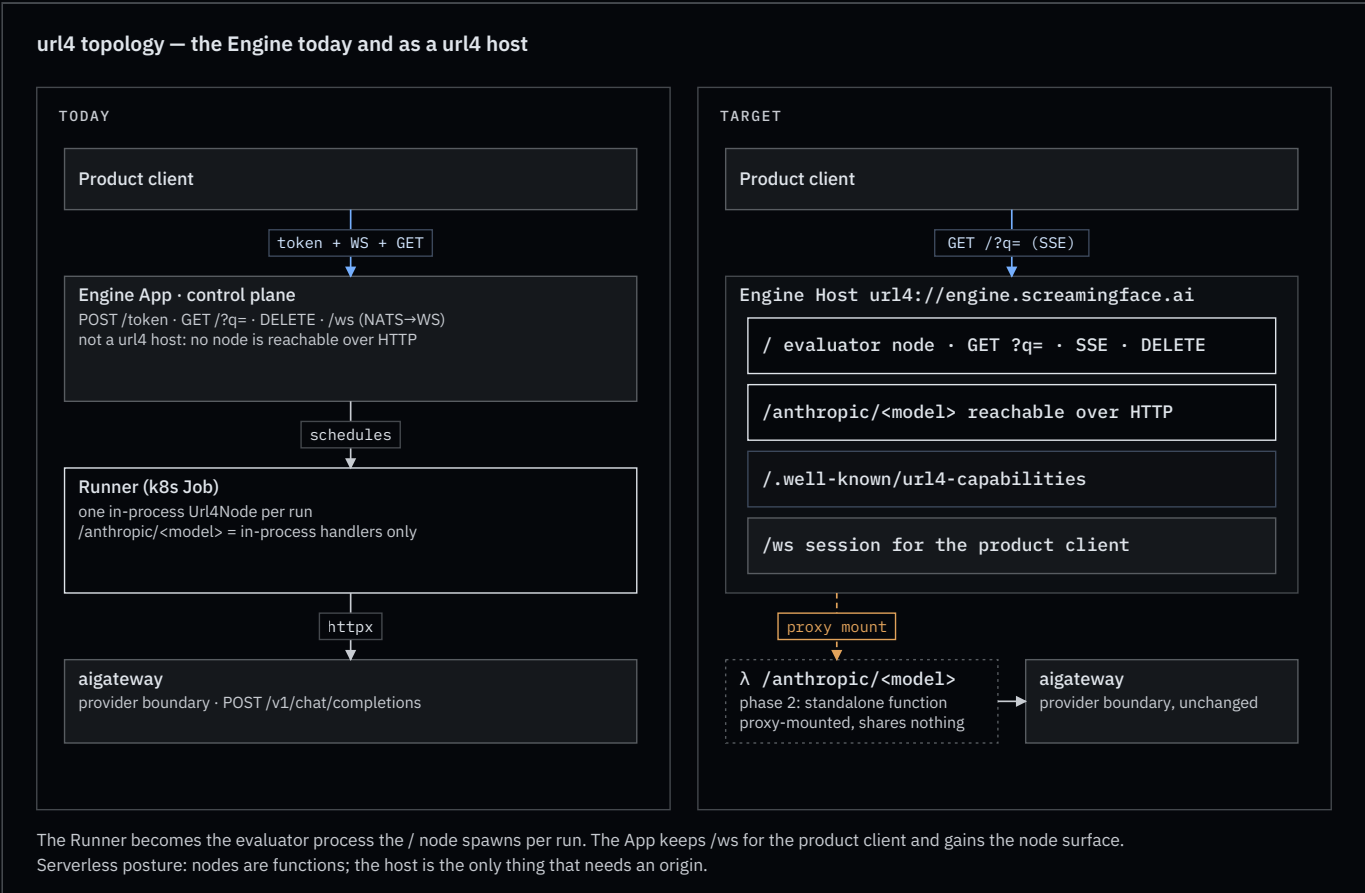
7. Telemetry

Three signals, one trace, as in the doctrine skill. What changes is where a one-shot GET puts them.

- **sync**: in the body. The envelope’s `meta` carries counts, latencies and cost at the level the requestor asked for (`none` , `summary` , `full` ; v0.2 §13.2). At `meta=full` a child’s envelope nests in `source.envelope` (v0.2 §13.3). Each node aggregates only what it saw itself (v0.2 §14.1).
- **stream**: as SSE events: logs, spans, `cost.usage` (self and subtree), then `result` , then `envelope` .
- **durable**: OTLP export to the trace backend. There is no separate “Enclave” store; the exporter superseded it.

This closes doctrine item F4. **Idempotency**: a url4 GET is idempotent in the HTTP sense (RFC 9110 §9.2.2): repeating it has no extra server-side effect. Results need not be identical; the spec’s §33 conflates the two (Appendix A).

8. The Engine as a host



Phases. (1) Host surface on the App: discovery per §5, `GET /?q=` with SSE, `DELETE` . (2) Model nodes over HTTP. (3) Standalone model functions, proxy-mounted, listed in the capabilities document.

Serverless posture. A node is a function; it needs no origin of its own. Only the host needs one. The Runner is already function-shaped. The App is not: it holds an audience count in memory, runs two perpetual tasks, and gates runs on an attached WebSocket. Those belong to the product session, not to the node surface, and stay in the App.

9. Deferred

- **Plan / preflight** as a defined concept. Today the SDK’s `Graph.validate()` checks syntax only and the Engine’s preflight checks routes on one host. Deferred by owner decision; §5 answers the practical question.
- **Swarm** as a protocol noun. Would need membership and trust rules that belong to the unwritten governance parts.
- **Node grades** (processor-only vs evaluator). Rejected: every node evaluates.

Appendix A — proposed spec deltas for Kevin

Each item names the anchor and the change. All are proposals.

1. **Part A §1.4 — rename.** Node → **Host** (“an origin implementing the protocol; mounts nodes”). Endpoint → **Node** (“a path on a host bound to an evaluator and an intent processor”). Add **Mount** (`local` | `command` | `proxy` , proxies declare their target).
2. **Part B §3.1.1, v0.2 §35.1 — root.** `url4://host` $\equiv$ `url4://host/` ; `/` is the host’s default node at the current version; `/v1` is a version alias.
3. **Part C §11.2 — stream binding.** `delivery=stream` is SSE on the same GET, requested with `Accept: text/event-stream` .
4. **Part C §11.4 — fallback floor.** Add `any` → `sync` . A node MAY answer a stream request with a sync response; the envelope’s `delivery` field says so. Not an error.
5. **v0.2 §33 (Part H in v0.5) — idempotency.** Replace “the protocol does not guarantee idempotency” with: GET is idempotent per RFC 9110 §9.2.2; results are not guaranteed deterministic.
6. **v0.2 §34 (Part H in v0.5) — cancellation.** `DELETE` on the run handle (`Location`). Terminal state `cancelled` ; SSE event `request.cancelled` ; propagates to in-flight children.
7. **Part G §27.2 — capabilities document.** Schema as drafted in §5: `nodes` keyed by path, `mount` , `target` , `delivery` , `features` ; `holdings` . Optional binding: the same entry as an `OPTIONS` body with `Content-Type: application/url4-capabilities+json` .

Appendix B — follow-up work items

To file after owner review, one per landing.

LANDING	ITEM
screamingface-engine	Host surface phase 1: discovery per §5, <code>GET /?q=</code> with SSE, <code>DELETE</code> on the run handle
screamingface-engine	Model nodes reachable over HTTP (phase 2); standalone model functions, proxy-mounted (phase 3)
screamingface-engine	Rename the <code>URL4-Capability</code> JWT header to avoid the “capabilities” collision
url4-sdk	SSE delivery in <code>Url4Node.asgi()</code> ; <code>delivery</code> param and <code>Accept</code> negotiation
url4-sdk	Capabilities document and/or <code>OPTIONS</code> responder, after the §5 decision
url4-sdk	<code>url4 serve</code> default path <code>/</code> ; <code>Client</code> default path <code>/</code> ; <code>/v1</code> alias
url4-sdk	<code>proxy</code> mount kind in <code>url4.toml</code>

LANDING	ITEM
url4-sdk	Url4Node → host naming retrofit with a deprecation alias
repo	Doctrine skill synced in this unit (T1, N1, F2, F4, term table)
Kevin	Review Appendix A

Appendix C — where the spec lives

- Parts A and B, v0.5 DRAFT (2026-07-10): `secondbrain/kevin-mcdonough/docs/adrs/URL4-Spec-A.md` , `URL4-Spec-B.md` .
- Parts C–I: “Not yet written” stubs (`.../adrs/site/part-c.html` ... `part-i.html`). Their content is the pre-v0.5 monolith, git `8a052dc:kevin-mcdonough/docs/adrs/URL4-Spec.md` , header v0.2. Cited here as “v0.2 §N”.
- Public docs: `public-docs/src/pages/learn/Url4Page.vue` . They use “fusion” and “typed DAG”; the spec uses neither.
- Doctrine: `.claude/skills/url4-engine/SKILL.md` , updated with this document.